Hindu custom and practice: ‘Again, the infidels perform their rituals . . . freely while the Muslims find themselves helpless and unable to execute ordinances of the sharia. On the day of Ekadashi when Hindus abstain from eating and drinking, they see to it that the Muslims also do not cook, sell or buy anything in the towns. On the contrary, in the month of Ramzan, they cook and sell breads in the bazaars openly.’[4]

Such was the animosity against the emperor that not all his critics confined their complaints to paper; some dreamt of more direct action. In 1582, the year that brought about the pitiful end of Abdun Nabi and Makhdum-ul-Mulk, the Jesuit Fathers of the first mission left Akbar’s court. Monserrate writes of this journey that he narrowly escaped being murdered by a soldier who, on learning that ‘the priest was a Christian and had been summoned by the King to teach him Christianity . . . plainly declared that, if he got a chance, he would kill not only the Priest but the King as well’.[5]

Some five years later, Abul Fazl records a murderous attack on a Shia priest called Mulla Ahmad in Lahore. In December 1587, a ‘hot-headed young [Sunni] man’ called Mirza Fulad Beg Barlas, sick and tired of Mulla Ahmad’s discourses on Shias and Sunnis, waylaid the priest and ‘cut off his arm’. It must have been a dark night: Fulad Beg thought he’d cut off Mulla Ahmad’s head, and left. The priest picked up his arm, went to a doctor, and managed to stay alive long enough to have his assailant arrested. Abul Fazl was part of the investigation and writes that even though ‘leading persons’ (that is, Akbar’s women relatives) petitioned for mercy, Fulad Beg was executed – tied to an elephant’s foot and paraded through the city. Mulla Ahmad died of his wounds a little later.

Badauni tells a more revealing tale. Evidently, Fulad Beg had support against the Shia priest – chronograms for his murder included ‘Bravo! the dagger of Steel’ and ‘Hell-fire Pig’. Badauni witnessed Mulla Ahmad’s death and swears that ‘I saw his face look actually like that of a pig’ as he breathed his last. More to the point, Badauni writes that Akbar sent an official to ask Fulad Beg what had possessed him to attack the priest – was it religious zeal? Fulad Beg replied, ‘If zeal for religion had been my motive, I should have turned my hand against a greater one than he.’ No wonder, with the man voicing such a clear threat to Akbar’s own life, that the emperor ignored his harem’s plea for mercy.